



TEACHING NOTE

Glossier: Co-Creating a Cult Brand with a Digital Community

Synopsis

Flush with cash from its Series C fundraise, cult beauty brand Glossier considers its next phase of growth, facing critical decisions on how to allocate its capital to support various marketing communications and distribution strategies. Glossier's proclaimed strategy was "born from content, fueled by community". The digital-first, direct-to-consumer beauty brand had experienced rapid growth, with sales up 600% in 2017 and a customer portfolio that grew by threefold. But, its founder, Emily Weiss, was not complacent. Instead, she dreamed of creating the world's first socially-driven brand that inserted its community into the buying experience so that the company was merchandising people, their opinions, and their content, just as much as they were merchandising products. As her team debates marketing strategies for 2018, they recognize the opportunities and challenges associated with managing Glossier's rapidly scaling brand community. While the community's support had emerged organically in the past, the team was now debating whether the company's next phase of growth would need to be fueled by a greater emphasis on paid peer-to-peer sales representatives, professional influencer marketing, paid media, and a physical market presence.

Learning Objectives

This case was developed for use in a second-year MBA course on *Creating Brand Value*. It has also been used successfully in several Executive Education programs, including *Launching New Ventures* and *Driving Digital Strategies*. The case allows a robust discussion of issues related to cult branding, social commerce, managing brand communities, crowdsourcing R&D, allocating owned, earned, and paid media, DTC e-commerce, physical retailing and pop-up retail strategies, peer-to-peer selling and influencer marketing, and nurturing consumer-brand relationships.

Glossier has one of the most admired brand communities of any of the new crop of direct-to-consumer brands. With this case, instructors can introduce the opportunities and challenges of co-creating brands alongside an active brand community and consider the following questions:

- What is the formula for creating a cult brand in today's marketplace?

This note was prepared by Senior Lecturer Jill Avery for the sole purpose of aiding classroom instructors in the use of "Glossier: Co-Creating a Cult Brand with a Digital Community," HBS No. 519-022. Funding for the development of this note was provided by Harvard Business School and not by the company. It provides analysis and questions that are intended to present alternative approaches to deepening students' comprehension of business issues and energizing classroom discussion. HBS cases are developed solely as the basis for class discussion. Cases are not intended to serve as endorsements, sources of primary data, or illustrations of effective or ineffective management.

Copyright © 2020 President and Fellows of Harvard College. To order copies or request permission to reproduce materials, call 1-800-545-7685, write Harvard Business School Publishing, Boston, MA 02163, or go to www.hbsp.harvard.edu. This publication may not be digitized, photocopied, or otherwise reproduced, posted, or transmitted, without the permission of Harvard Business School.

- What is social commerce and how might one assess its potential for changing the way consumers discover, shop for, and consume products and services?
- Should firms turn their customers into influencers? How can firms jointly manage maximizing customer lifetime value and customer social value by encouraging their customers to engage in social commerce activities?
- What value do consumers gain from being active members in online brand communities?
- How can/should managers capitalize on the value created for consumers in brand communities?
- How should brand managers establish, build, nurture, and grow brand communities?
- Can digitally-native DTC brands stay digital-only or do they need to break out into the physical world? How does that move affect the brand community?
- How do online and offline owned, paid, and earned media combine to transmit and build a brand's story? How can a brand community help with marketing communications?

Assignment Questions

- 1.) How should Glossier best deploy the \$52 million infusion of capital it has just received from its Series C fundraise?
- 2.) Which of the four paid media programs (peer-to-peer sales representatives, influencer marketing, paid media, and customer loyalty program) should Glossier pursue? Why? How might each of these programs change its relationships with its customers?
- 3.) Assess Glossier's distribution strategy options. Should the company open more showrooms? Should it do more pop-ups? Should it begin selling wholesale to retailers like Sephora? Why or why not? How might each of these decisions affect its relationships with its customers?
- 4.) Across the marketing mix, how can Glossier best utilize its brand community? How does your answer to this question change as the Glossier community exponentially scales?
- 5.) Assess the strength of the Glossier brand. From what does its strength derive? What weaknesses do you perceive? How sustainable are its brand-related competitive advantages? Why?
- 6.) Is "best friends" the most effective relational template for Glossier's desired relationship with its customers? Why or why not? What excites you and what worries you about this type of relationship?

Teaching the Case

There are five main areas the discussion of this case should cover. These include the discussion pastures and lines of questioning outlined in **TN Table 1**, which account for 75 minutes of discussion and leave 5 minutes for an instructor-led wrap:

TN Table 1 Glossier: Co-Creating a Cult Brand with a Digital Community

	Opening Question	Line of Questioning
Pasture 1: Building Brand Equity (15 minutes)	Brand managers are tasked with building two long-lived assets for the firm: brand equity (the value that the brand brings to the purchase beyond the generic value of the product) and customer equity (the value that the consumer-brand relationship generates). Let's consider each of these in turn. First, what can we learn from Glossier's game plan about building a cult brand?	Which aspects of Glossier's strategy were most successful at creating brand equity? Why? How strong of a brand is Glossier? From what does it derive its strength? Reverse engineer how Glossier built its brand. What has worked well for them and what has not? How strong is the brand's value proposition? How sustainable are the competitive advantages that its brand equity provides? What worries you about the brand? As Glossier marches closer to an IPO, what opportunities and challenges do you see for creating additional brand value?
Pasture 2: Building Customer Equity (15 minutes)	What can we learn from Glossier's playbook about creating customer equity? What has Glossier done to build customer equity?	How does Glossier work to increase its average Customer Lifetime Value and Customer Lifetime Social Value (CLSV)? How has Glossier helped people raise their Customer Social Value (CSV) or the value that each customer has on the purchases of other customers? How do <i>Into the Gloss</i> (ITG) readers and Glossier customers positively and negatively affect each other? What value do ITG readers and contributors supply to Glossier customers? What value do Glossier customers supply to ITG readers? How would you calculate the CSV of each type of person? Do you buy into Emily Weiss's vision of social commerce? Why or why not?

Opening Question		Line of Questioning
		What worries you about Glossier's relationships with its customers?
		As Glossier marches closer to an IPO, what opportunities and challenges do you see for creating additional customer equity value?
		Is it ethical to merchandise consumers' ideas and opinions? Why? What downsides do you see?
Pasture 3: Consumer-Brand Relationship Templating (15 minutes)	Is "best friends" the most effective relational template for Glossier's desired relationship with its customers? Why or why not?	What excites you and what worries you about this type of relationship? What are the expectations associated with a best friendship? How well can Glossier hold up its side of the relationship? How does this change as the brand continues to scale? What other relational types might be better for Glossier? Why? Given its relationships with current customers, does Glossier need a customer loyalty program? Why or why not? If yes, how would you design it and what are you hoping to achieve?
Pasture 4: Brand Community Engagement (15 minutes)	How should Glossier best engage and utilize its brand community? How can its brand community help with delivering its marketing mix?	Role of community in promotion strategy? Should they hire community members to serve as peer-to-peer sales reps? Should Glossier commit to a paid influencer model or continue to rely on unpaid influencers? Why? How might a paid influencer model affect Glossier's brand story? How might a paid influencer model affect Glossier's relationships with its community?

	Opening Question	Line of Questioning
		Role of community in product development and R&D? As Glossier scales, how sustainable is its community engagement strategy? Which parts scale and which don't?
Pasture 5: Distribution Strategy (15 minutes)	How can Glossier maximize its brand value given the recent infusion of \$52 million? How would you spend the money?	Would you expand beyond DTC e-commerce? Why or why not? Would you continue to open flagship stores? Why or why not? Would you consider Sephora as a wholesaler partner? Why or why not? Would you double down on DTC e-commerce and spend the money on paid marketing to drive consumers to your website and mobile app? Why or why not? Would you spend it on paid media? Why or why not? How big can Glossier get if it stays DTC e-commerce only? Is there a ceiling to its growth? Why or why not? How do each of these options change Glossier's relationship with its consumers and its brand community?

Each of these pastures is discussed at length below with supporting analysis.

Analyzing the Case

Instructors will rely on three bodies of consumer literature to support the Glossier case discussion. Suggestions for additional readings from this literature for instructors to assign to students alongside the case or to further their own education are listed at the end of the note:

1. **Consumer-Brand Relationships:** how and why consumers form relationships with brands, the different forms of those relationships, the expectations that accompany a particular form, and how those expectations and the firm's ability to deliver against them build value for customers and allow the firm to extract value to fuel a business model.

2. **Managing Brand Communities:** how and why consumers band together in brand communities, the value that they derive from doing so, and how brand managers can leverage that value to create value for the firm.
3. **Social Commerce and Influencer Marketing:** how and why consumers influence and are influenced by each other and how commerce can be restructured as social commerce to insert peer-to-peer influence at all points of a customer's purchase decision journey.

Pasture 1 Reverse-Engineering Glossier's Success Formula for Building Brand Equity

Instructors can introduce the class session by reminding students that Glossier has just closed a significant venture capital funding round, their Series C, which has brought an additional \$52 million into the firm's coffers. Emily and her team must figure out the best way to invest that money to help scale the business and move it toward profitability, in preparation for an eventual initial public offering (IPO) or acquisition. There are a lot of different options on the table, some including media strategies (whether to invest in paid media, paid influencer marketing, or the development of a peer-to-peer sales force), distribution strategies (whether to invest in opening more showrooms, limited time only pop-up retail experiences, or sell to wholesale accounts), and technological solutions (whether to continue to invest in the technology platform to support Emily's vision for social commerce). Spending the money wisely will allow Glossier to grow, to turn profitable, and to continue to build upon its competitive advantages. Spending the money poorly risks all of these outcomes and has the potential to damage the two assets the company has so assiduously built over its first few years: brand equity and customer equity.

Before jumping into decisions about how to spend the money, instructors may want to begin the discussion by asking students to reverse-engineer Glossier's success formula to better understand how it has been able to build brand equity and customer equity. Unpacking its success will enable students to make better decisions for the future that protect the competencies, structures, processes, and assets that have made the company thrive thus far. The discussion can be broken into two pieces: first, focusing on how Glossier has built brand equity in Pasture 1, then focusing on how Glossier has built customer equity in its relationships with consumers in Pasture 2, or instructors can ask a general reverse-engineering success question and then use the boards to divide students' responses into two flows of ideas that represent the building blocks for brand equity and customer equity.

- Brand Equity is a measure of the brand's value to the firm; it is the sum of the intangible assets and liabilities linked to a brand that add to or subtract from its value. On a micro-level, brand equity arises from the differential responses consumers have to products when they are branded. On a macro-level, brand equity is measured as the stream of incremental profits that accrue from the sale of branded products over and above the profits that would have accrued from the sale of the same products unbranded. This approach recognizes that brand equity drives not only a revenue premium, but also cost savings. Products with strong brands gain efficiencies in marketing costs because consumers are more receptive and responsive to the brand's messages. Brand equity is also credited with allowing a company to efficiently expand beyond its current business via the extension of the brand into new markets or product categories. Finally, a strong brand provides its holder with a stronger negotiating position vis-à-vis its wholesale distribution network, leading to cost savings.
- Customer Equity represents the value of the customer relationships contained in the company's customer portfolio or the combined total customer lifetime value of all of the company's customers. Customers both cost the company money, as the company invests to acquire and

serve them and provide revenues and profits back to the company in the form of their purchases over time. The (simplified) customer lifetime value (CLV) calculation captures this relationship between costs and revenues and illustrates the three levers that marketers use to create value for the firm: 1.) acquiring customers efficiently, 2.) maximizing revenue and minimizing cost to serve while they remain customers to generate margin enhancement, and 3.) retaining customers over time:^a

$$\text{CLV} = (\text{Gross Profit per Year} * \text{Years in Lifetime}) - \text{Customer Acquisition Cost}$$

Some of the success factors that students cite as building Glossier's brand equity include:

- A different type of brand story versus traditional “big” beauty brands, which focuses on the concept that every woman is beautiful and that beauty is democratic and inclusive, rather than exclusive,
- An inquisitive, engaging stance versus an authoritative brand voice, a friendly brand personality,
- Inexpensively obtained brand awareness and brand knowledge that flows from both the company's paid media efforts as well as customer-to-customer word-of-mouth, as earned media accounts for 50% of brand impressions and peer-to-peer communications account for 20%, compared to the more expensive paid media which accounts for 30%,
- Content generation from *Into the Gloss* (ITG) that introduces consumers to the brand, builds trust and relationships through conversation and collaboration, and converts them to Glossier products. ITG readers were 40% more likely to purchase Glossier products than non-readers, but a large percentage of ITG readers were not Glossier customers,
- ITG allows Glossier to inexpensively fill the top of the purchase funnel with owned media. Interestingly, Emily builds audience for four years (2010-2014) before she tries to sell products to that audience in 2014 with the launch of Glossier. This allows her to create an incredible sense of trust with consumers, as she gives them a lot of value for a long time without extracting any/much of that value for her company. Most companies try to sell a product first, and then try to build a brand community later, which comes across as commercially-motivated rather than altruistic. Says Glossier in the case, “The one thing we’ve always done well since our first days is that we create wonderful content. We are great editors. That’s our competitive advantage. A lot of e-commerce companies built their commerce platform first and then figured out that they needed content to drive consumers to it. We came to commerce the other way around. We were content editors first before we went into commerce. That matters.”
- Emily herself, who serves as a credible and appealing spokesperson for the brand,
- A brand “whose sweatshirt you want to wear” – turning a beauty brand into an identity brand through lifestyle branding,
- Branded experiences at the showroom and pop-ups that bring the brand to life,
- Simplistic and photographic product packaging that encourages social media sharing,

^a For a more sophisticated look and mathematical calculations of customer lifetime value, please see Steenburgh, Thomas and Jill Avery “Marketing Analysis Toolkit: Customer Lifetime Value,” *Harvard Business School Technical Note*, No. 9-511-029.

- Consumer buy-in to new products as they believe their opinions helped shaped the products,
- Scarcity and anticipation from the way the company launches new products and manages waiting lists,
- Some students may suggest product quality accounts for Glossier's brand success, while others might question this assumption. There is no data in the case to suggest that Glossier has better or worse product quality than other beauty brands. However, some students may argue that the fact the Emily listens and understands the needs of her customers and crowdsources new product ideas from them enables her to make better products. Other students may argue that Emily largely outsources R&D and manufacturing to contract manufacturing partners, making it unlikely that her product formulations are any different from anything else that is available on the market. Still others may argue that big beauty companies, such as those mentioned in **Case Exhibit 4**, are likely to have cutting edge, patented formulas and many scientists working to produce the next innovations.

Pasture 2 Customer Social Value: Building Customer Equity

Continuing the discussion of Glossier's success formula, instructors can begin to transition students toward a consideration of how the company builds customer equity, using questioning to guide students through a consideration of the concept of Customer Social Value (CSV) and how that affects customer lifetime value. Customer social value is an additional term that can be added to the customer lifetime value calculation that reflects a customer's peer impact on the purchasing of other consumers that stems from their involvement in social commerce activities, such as sharing product or brand information, opinions, and experiences, such that:^b

$$\text{Customer Lifetime Social Value (CLSV)} = \text{CLV} + \text{CSV}$$

Customer social value recognizes that consumers create value for firms from their own purchasing (which is captured in the standard CLV calculation) as well as through their actions that influence other consumers to buy (a customer's social value). Through word-of-mouth, influencer marketing, brand community engagement, crowdsourcing, content co-creation, and other social commerce-related actions, consumers engage in marketing and sales activities normally conducted by firms. These activities generate brand awareness and brand knowledge among other consumers, increase their brand consideration, influence their brand evaluations, assist with their trial, purchase, and use of the brand, and promote post-purchase behaviors that allow these other consumers to begin to generate their own customer social value. Customer social value impacts all three levers contained in the customer lifetime value calculations. Through their actions, consumers' social commerce activities allow firms to acquire other customers more inexpensively, to retain them longer due to their attachment and commitment to their fellow consumers and to the brand community, and to earn more profits from them while they are customers by allowing them to feel part of the co-creation of the brand and its product line through participation in crowdsourcing activities.

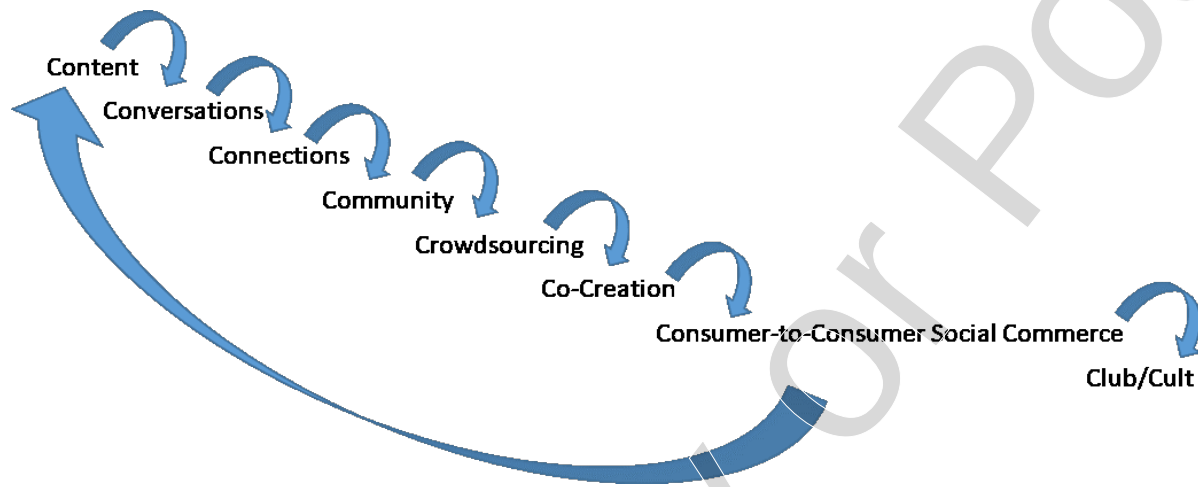
Some of the success factors that students cite as building Glossier's customer equity include:

^b Instructors may reference Ofek, Elie; Barak Libai and Eitan Muller (2018) "Customer Lifetime Social Value (CLSV)," Harvard Business School Technical Note No. 9-518-077 for more information about how to conceptualize and calculate Customer Social Value.

- The sense of customer-centricity, that her audience and her customers are the most important thing to Emily, more important even than making a profit,
- Strong customer experience (CX) team who takes time to relate to customers, rather than rush them off the phone,
- ITG's content, which creates conversations between the company and prospective customers,
- The personal connections or parasocial relationships that Glossier's consumers form with Emily, its employees, and with each other,
- The sense of community that forms around the brand as consumers interact with it digitally and physically,
- Brand as peer, rather than brand as authority,
- The participatory nature of Glossier's and ITG's crowdsourcing, which allows consumers to feel a sense of ownership for the brand,
- Brand co-creation opportunities, which allow consumers to shape the brand to suit their needs,
- Consumer-to-consumer social commerce, which invites Glossier's consumers to share their brand experiences with others,
- The club or cult that forms around the brand because it is small and unknown (and thus to be a Glossier Girl is still something unique and special, which allows consumers to feel in-the-know and cutting edge about their purchases). Religious cults or imagery are often invoked by students during this part of the discussion and should be explored via probing questions by the instructor. To many, Emily is an evangelizing messianic figure to the Glossier community and she is selling more than just beauty products, but also self-esteem and a new vision for beauty. Like any religion, she has a mantra and followers adhere to her mythology.
- Glossier's direct-to-consumer model, which allows the company to own the relationship with each consumer and to gather individualized, identifiable data about their customers.

Instructors can use the diagram outlined in **TN Figure 1** to capture the connections among these concepts on the boards and to show how each contributes to a reinforcing system for building brand equity and customer equity, what Davis labels "a beautiful virtuous circle."¹ Content starts conversations, which establish connections among consumers, which allow for the creation and maintenance of a brand community, which allow the company to use crowdsourcing for its R&D, which permits consumers to co-create Glossier's product line and brand, which promotes consumer-to-consumer social commerce (evangelizing the brand to others, providing earned media via word-of-mouth and organic influencer marketing), which reinforces the community to help it feel like a club or a cult. All of these activities generate additional content for Glossier with consumers playing a major brand authorial role.

TN Figure 1 Building Brand Equity and Customer Equity



Source: Casewriter.

The 8 C's outlined above are all involved in helping Glossier's consumers raise their customer social value (CSV).

Following the elicitation of various success factors and the illumination of Glossier's success at nurturing customer social value, instructors can turn the discussion to Glossier's vulnerabilities, to guide students through a discussion of whether the brand equity and customer equity building activities in which Glossier has engaged 1.) have led to sustainable competitive advantage and 2.) are scalable as the company grows. Students often entertain the following worries about the company's strategy:

- **Profitability Concerns:** While some students will argue that Glossier's direct-to-consumer model allows the company to avoid paying large retailer margins to channel partners (the case mentions that Sephora would charge 40-50% margins to sell Glossier's products in its stores), other students will point to the high level of customer acquisition cost (CAC) the company must expend to acquire a customer (\$52.50). Although Glossier saves paying a retailer margin by going DTC, it has to pick up and fund all of the jobs that the retailer would have done for them, such as acquiring customers, holding inventory, processing the sales, picking/packing/shipping orders, providing pre- and post-sales assistance, and handling returns. The cost of doing these jobs might exceed the 40-50% margin they would pay to a retailer.

Given Glossier's low price points (\$12-60), small basket sizes (\$57.00), fickle beauty consumers who flit among many different brands, and an intensively competitive environment, Glossier might have a hard time turning the corner to profitability if its consumers do not come back to rebuy products frequently. Given that the company has a very limited product line (26 items), cross-selling opportunities are limited. However, Glossier helps re-attract customers by having a continuous flow of new product introductions every 6 weeks, which generates buzz and repurchase consideration.

- **Scaling Concerns:** Glossier and ITG have thrived on customer intimacy and the parasocial relationships that Emily has formed with her customers. Glossier's brand cool may rely on the

small size of its brand community and the feelings of being “in-the-know” of its early consumers. Can the brand scale and keep this sense of belonging or will letting too many people into the club ruin it?

- **Competitive Concerns:** Students often bring up other successful startup beauty brands, such as Drunk Elephant, Fenty, or Milk, that are turning consumers’ heads and that might have brand stories and brand communities that are more exciting and novel than Glossier. Beauty is a highly competitive category and Glossier, although well-funded by its venture partners, is competing against large multi-brand corporations with deep pockets and competing against thousands of innovative startups, many of which are backed by well-known and admired celebrities such as Rihanna (Fenty). Barriers to entry in beauty are very low – easy access to contract manufacturing and consumers’ willingness to purchase beauty products via direct-to-consumer e-commerce allows anyone to jump into the business at any time with little upfront investment.
- **Direct-to-Consumer Ceiling Concerns:** Some students will argue that Glossier’s DTC model place a ceiling on its growth and profitability, particularly in the short term. 80% of beauty and skin care products are still sold at physical retail, making it difficult to convert consumers to DTC e-commerce. CACs are rising in digital media, making it more expensive for Glossier to acquire customers.
- **Limited Target Market:** Given the clubbiness of Glossier’s consumers, some students argue that their target market of pre-teens and teens might be too narrow and not have enough purchasing power nor brand loyalty to fund a profitable business model and recommend expanding the target to older consumers. Other students push back on this recommendation, claiming that customer segment expansion risks both the cool of Glossier and consumers’ desire to be in the club.

Pasture 3 Consumer-Brand Relationship Templating and Analysis

Glossier has formed particularly strong relationships with and among its early consumers, relationships that resemble human friendships. Emily intentionally builds friendship relations with customers through the intimate way she addresses them in communications, through her accessibility to them via the *Into the Gloss* blog and to her employees via the Slack Group, through the sense of “clubbiness” she engenders among them, and through her willingness to include and embrace their voices in creating her brand’s story.

In this pasture, instructors should guide students through an analysis of Glossier’s consumer-brand relationships to induce the type of relationship Emily has built (friendship) and to understand how she has done so. The pasture should also be used to analyze whether this type of consumer-brand relationship is the right type for Glossier and what the upsides and downsides of becoming “friends” with your customers might be.

First, instructors can ask students to assess the strength of Glossier’s consumer-brand relationships, eliciting the factors that students believe determine relational strength and assessing the brand’s performance of those factors. Consumer researcher Susan Fournier developed a six-faceted Brand Relationship Quality scale² to measure the six factors which combine to make relationships strong and enduring. They include:

- Love and Passion. Consumers feel a strong emotional attachment to the brand and feel anxious when the brand is not available to them. Glossier's customers show high levels of love and passion for the brand.
- Self-Connection. Consumers feel a strong connection between the brand and their personal identity. The brand represents an important aspect of the consumer's self. Glossier consumers feel a sense of connection to Emily, her employees, and other Glossier girls.
- Interdependence. Consumers have a high level of interaction with the brand. Interactions are emotionally important to the consumer. The brand has become part of important rituals in the consumer's life. Glossier consumers are proud to declare their allegiance to the brand by posting selfies, by crowdsourcing their ideas for new product introductions, and by making pilgrimages to Glossier's showroom and pop-up events.
- Commitment. Consumers feel and demonstrate commitment to the brand in the face of adversity. Consumers may also derogate competing brands. While it seems that Glossier's consumers are committed to the brand, it is unlikely that they use it for all of their beauty and skin care needs. In fact, Emily acknowledges that her consumers will not exclusively use Glossier products, but will mix them in with their other beloved brands. She does not expect total commitment, loyalty, and 100% share of wallet from her customers.
- Intimacy. Consumers know a great deal about the brand or the brand firm. Brand knowledge is highly personalized and connected to the self. Emily's straightforward, intimate manner and her self-revelation on the *Into the Gloss* blog has gone a long way toward creating intimacy with her customers. Customers reveal their intimate thoughts and photos (#TopShelfie) with the firm and expect the firm to act upon their revelations by producing products that meet their needs. Glossier's DTC model allows customers intimacy through the data trace it produces about each customer.
- Brand Partner Quality. Consumers believe that the brand is a worthy relationship partner. Consumers believe the brand cares about them and that the brand will act in their best interest to protect their relationship. Consumers believe the brand is reliable, trustworthy, dependable, and predictable. Glossier's customers see Emily as a trusted friend and a confidant. She is aspirational to them.

Which types of relationships do consumers form with their brands? Historically, marketers have viewed consumer-brand relationships purely as economic exchanges. According to psychologists Margaret Clark and Judson Mills, we typically have exchange relationships with strangers or mere acquaintances and the purpose of these types of relationship is often business. People in exchange relationships expect quid-pro-quo for everything they put into it, "members assume that benefits are given with the expectation of receiving a benefit in return".³ In exchange relationships, consumers engage with a brand to receive something from the brand that is equal to or exceeds the consumer's investment in the relationship. Following neoclassical economic theory, consumers are viewed as rational, self-interested, economic beings who engage in relationships with brands purely to maximize the utility they receive from them.

However, consumer behavior in the marketplace tells quite a different story. Consumer anthropologists have documented relationships with a much different flavor; consumers of brands such as Harley-Davidson, Apple, Porsche, Star Trek, and Krispy Kreme donuts are much more passionate about their brands than the exchange relationship model predicts. The relationships these consumers have with their brands more closely resemble communal relationships we have with

important people in our lives, like our family and our closest friends. In communal relationships, consumers are less self-interested and more interested in the brand as a relationship partner, demonstrating concern for the brand and its needs and for the continuation of the relationship (Aggarwal 2004). Communal consumer-brand relationships are sometimes described as marriages, in which the consumer loves the brand, is highly loyal and committed to it over time, and derives great psychological and social benefit from the relationship. Consumers with communal brand relationships usually demonstrate high levels of brand loyalty, a strong emotional attachment to the brand and frequent and/or exclusive purchase of it.

Fournier's work on consumer-brand relationships⁴ suggests that commercial relationships with brands exhibit the following tenets:

- They are functional: At their core, consumer-brand relationships provide meaning to the people who engage in them.
- They are multiplex and resemble human relationships in form and content: They range across several dimensions and take many forms. Their forms are defined by sets of rules that coalesce into a contract. Not all consumer-brand relationships are "loyal" or even positive.
- They are dynamic: They are ever-evolving, reciprocating engagements, defined by the expectations and actions of two parties as they interact.

Her work also illustrates the wide variety of types of consumer-brand relationships that exist in the current marketplace landscape, each of which comes with its own rules and expectations of both parties, including: arranged marriages, casual friends/buddies, marriages of convenience, committed partnerships, best friendships, compartmentalized friendships, kinships, rebounds/avoidance-driven relationships, childhood friendships, courtships, dependencies, flings, enmities, secret affairs, and enslavements.

Consumer-brand relationships, like human relationships, are complex things, and governed by their underlying relationship contracts: the rules by which the relationship is governed and through which partner actions are determined and engaged. Relationship rules prescribe, proscribe, or permit particular types of behaviors; they serve to illuminate the social conduct which is obligatory, prohibited, expected, or allowed within a particular relationship. There are many different types of relationship rules in the consumer-brand space and instructors can ask students to define the rules that govern Glossier's relationships with its customers and determine whether those rules can be followed in a way that produces a viable business model.

- Reward rules arbitrate the most essential exchange terms of the contract: what the consumer and the brand will give to and get from the relationship.
- Interaction rules govern how and when the firm and consumer will engage and communicate with one another.
- Some rules govern the development and expression of intimacy, trust, and commitment in the relationship; others guide what constitutes conflict and how it is expected to be assuaged.
- All relationships have an "ultimate rule," that if broken, violates the relationship at its core.

The "best friends" consumer-brand template is defined by Fournier as a "voluntary union based on [a] reciprocity principle, the endurance of which is ensured through continued provision of positive rewards. [It is] characterized by [a] revelation of the true self, honesty, and intimacy. Congruity in

partner images and personal images [is] common.”⁵ As such, it comes with some rules attached that both parties (the brand as partner and the consumer) are expected to follow in order to nurture and build the relationship. They are summarized in **TN Figure 2**:

TN Figure 2 Consumer-Brand Relationship Template: Friendship

The Friendship Template		
Friendship	Guiding norm	<i>Always be there for each other</i>
	Key operative relationship rules	<i>Make each other happy Open, honest, two-way communication Don't betray the friendship</i>
	Relationship purpose	<i>Assistance, Emotional support, Intimacy</i>
	Brand personality	<i>Friendly, nice, caring, responsive</i>
	Perceived Customer Role	<i>Supportive, easy-going, helpful</i>

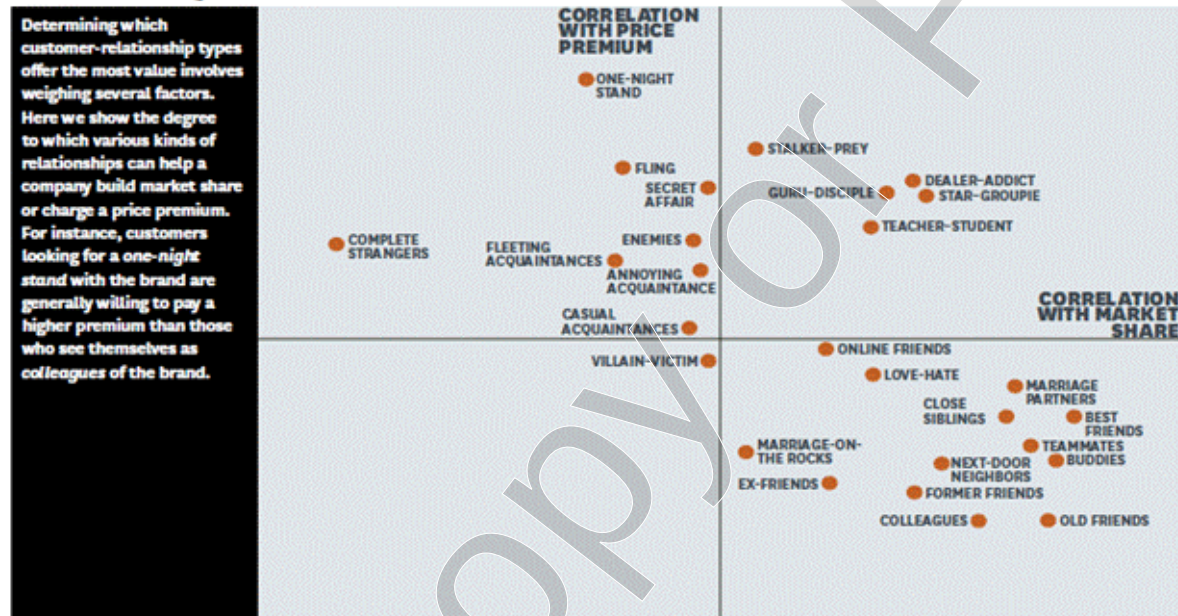
Source: Casewriter.

Instructors can guide students through a discussion of whether the rules of friendship are advantageous to Glossier and whether they will allow the company to use its competencies to create value for customers and extract enough value to fuel a profitable business model. One of the challenges of forming best friendships with your customers is the high partner expectations that come with this type of relationship. Glossier will have to invest significantly in its customer experience (CX) function and in customer relationship management programs as it scales to be able to deliver the type of high-touch, high-access service it has become known for thus far. The sense of intimacy the brand has enjoyed with its customers will also be challenging as the number of customers increases and Emily is not able to personally engage with each one.

TN Figure 3 illustrates the profit potential (via price premium) and market share potential of different types of consumer-brand relationships. Best friendships yields large market share potential, but less profit potential than other types of relationships due to high costs associated with their underlying relationship contracts.

TN Figure 3 The Profitability and Loyalty Value of Different Types of Consumer-Brand Relationships

VALUING “FRIENDS” AND “ACQUAINTANCES”



Source: Avery, Jill; Susan Fournier, and John Wittenbraker (2014) “Unlock the Mysteries of Your Customer Relationships” *Harvard Business Review*, July/August 2014.

Instructors may close this pasture with a short discussion of whether Glossier should invest in a customer loyalty program. Given the above analysis of its friendship relationship, some students are likely to feel that the company does not need to invest in a customer loyalty program, as loyalty is a fundamental tenet of a friendship relationship and that Glossier’s customers appear to be quite loyal to the company already. However, some students will suggest that Glossier has an opportunity to increase its customers’ lifetime value (LTV) by encouraging customers to buy more of their products more frequently and that therefore, a traditional purchase-based loyalty program would yield positive financial results. Given the small order size (\$57.00) and the high customer acquisition cost (CAC) (\$52.50), Glossier needs to find ways to increase the LTV of a customer in order to pay back its CAC and begin to earn profits on customers.

Other students will suggest that a loyalty program that uses financial rewards (such as reward points or frequent purchaser programs that offer discounts on future purchases) feels inappropriate for a friendship relationships as it is too mercenary and not aligned with purchasing motivations and values received from this type of relationship. Others argue that it is not necessary to discount the price of a Glossier product, as customers are motivated by other values other than economic value when they purchase the brand. Students might suggest other types of loyalty programs that recognize the social commerce efforts of Glossier’s customers and reward them with non-monetary benefits and/or status, such as a “best friend” badge or inclusion in exclusive “insider” events, like meet-ups with Emily.

Pasture 4 Brand Community Engagement

In the opening pastures, students usually identify Glossier's brand community as a key asset of the company and a sustainable competitive advantage. The creation of a well-functioning brand community creates value to consumers and to firms. Consumer researchers Albert Muniz and Thomas O'Guinn identify a brand community by three markers,⁶ all of which are evident in Glossier's customer relationships and all of which provide value to Glossier's consumers:

1. **A Shared Consciousness:** The members of the Glossier community feel a sense of "we-ness", a collective identity that allows them to feel a sense of kinship with other Glossier consumers and to see themselves as fundamentally different and better than others who do not use Glossier. Emily's evangelizing about new beauty and her disdain for "Big Beauty" helps create this sense of us versus them from other beauty brands. Glossier consumers, led by Emily, have created a new sense of beauty and a new way of thinking about what is beautiful than what traditional beauty myths have perpetuated. A sense of shared consciousness helps consumers achieve a strong sense of belonging to the Glossier community.
2. **Rituals and Traditions:** The members of the Glossier community state their membership in the club and recognize each other by engaging in rituals and traditions, such as posting to social media using #glossier, carrying their pink bubble wrap bags in public, making pilgrimages to Glossier's pop-ups and showrooms, and reading and posting to ITG. Rituals and traditions allow Glossier's consumers to feel like they are part of something bigger than themselves.
3. **A Sense of Moral Responsibility:** Emily has created a sense of moral responsibility in the Glossier brand community, where Glossier Girls help each other with beauty advice and where the company is seen as a benevolent helper rather than as an authoritarian dictator. The sense of moral responsibility enables Glossier's consumers to feel important as they engage in social commerce activities, in that they are expected to help others and to receive help with their own purchasing.

Participation in brand communities enables consumers to receive many different types of value from their relationship with the brand. As they consume the brand's products while embedded in a brand community, they now not only receive functional value from the product, but also ego-expressive value from being perceived as a Glossier Girl, emotional value from being connected to Emily and other Glossier consumers, experiential value from participating in brand conversations and co-creation activities, social value from feeling part of the club or cult, and mythical value from consuming a brand that is changing the face of beauty and making more women feel beautiful.

Instructors may use a discussion of Emily's social commerce vision to unpack theories related to influencer marketing and peer-to-peer selling and to explore their effectiveness, efficiency, and ethics. The case outlines Emily's philosophy for social commerce as follows:

- "born from content, fueled by community,"
- "using relationships to fundamentally change the way women discovered and purchased beauty products,"
- "to create a social brand sold via human-centered social commerce,"
- "the first socially-driven brand, the first beauty brand that involves its community in its creative process,"

- “inserting people into the buying experience, so that we’re merchandising people’s opinions and stories just as much as we are merchandising products,”
- “We’re striving not for a breadth of assortment like Amazon, but rather for a breadth of human connections,”
- “Influence has been completely decentralized and now is in the hands of individual consumers. You don’t have to listen to a brand, you can listen to literally hundreds of people.”
- “Vertically Integrated,” a self-contained demand-side value chain that reunited the processes of discovery, purchase, and fulfillment...creating relationships among people through *Into The Gloss*, learning about their needs, translating those desires into products, and creating an end-to-end discovery-to-purchase-to-fulfillment-to-consumption-to-sharing process that enchanted and inspired consumers to connect closely with the brand and each other.”
- “We want to create a digital party – the equivalent of a party that has a line down the block to get in and people are talking about it as a great party, not one that you have to pay celebrities to go to...We want to build a shopping experience that is so great that people just naturally flock to it.”
- “How do you help people discover products in the way that they naturally want to – by talking to others?...how do you balance shopping with social?”
- “This is about the experience. How do we offer you an experience that is different, that makes you feel special, and makes you feel a part of something? How do we create a different kind of loyalty? By bringing people together online, you can create experiences that haven’t previously existed before.”
- “How can we connect you to someone who has similar interests, to help you or just share your shopping experience? How can we allow you to harness our community to enrich your shopping experience? We want you to come to Glossier.com, go through product discovery, check out, and be completely surprised by what happened along the way. You didn’t expect to interact with people in the way that you did, but not only do you feel good about your purchase, but you feel good about having contributed to the conversation, to the community, and you’re eager to share with others what just happened and just as eager to go back yourself, even if you just return to enrich someone else’s buying experience.”
- “Emily has a belief that you can combine an online community with an e-commerce platform. She believes that people will want to hang out on Glossier.com just like they do on *Into The Gloss* – that it won’t just be about shopping. No one else is creating a space like this – where you’ll interact with a community one day and then the next day you’ll go back and shop.”

Emily’s social commerce vision is built upon using consumer-to-consumer communication, influence, and advocacy in all parts of the customer decision journey, from discovery through to purchase and consumption. This involves crowdsourcing (providing purchasers with access to all of the opinions and reviews of customers) and the production of consumer-to-consumer bonds (allowing a prospective customer to find a peer like them to help them through the purchase process). Instructors might use **TN Figure 4** to demonstrate this end-to-end social commerce approach, which turns purchasing from either a solo journey or a journey where a consumer engages only with company representatives to one where she feels supported by a friend or a group of friends along every step of the way.

TN Figure 4 Social Commerce Supports Consumers at All Stages of the Purchase Journey

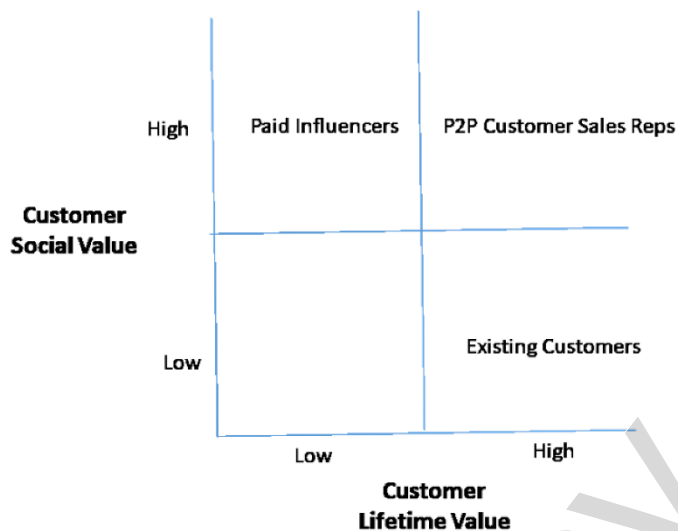
Source: Casewriter.

The case also states that Glossier invests significant money in its technological platform and staff to support social commerce (50 people or 1/3 of Glossier current staff work in technology) and to create a new type of e-commerce that stands in opposition to Amazon. Students should explore whether this investment (and the significant future investment required to fully realize Emily's vision) is warranted and how consumers are likely to respond to this type of digital exploration, buying, and consuming experience.

Instructors can use the questions of whether Glossier should invest in promoting more social commerce activities by building a peer-to-peer sales force, turning their existing customers into paid salespeople, or whether Glossier should invest in paid influencer marketing, to bring out themes related to the importance of authenticity in persuasion.

The matrix in **TN Figure 5** may be helpful in structuring the discussion to link these activities to the creation of customer lifetime value and customer social value:

TN Figure 5 Maximizing CLV and CSV



Source: Casewriter.

Most existing customers currently contribute high customer lifetime value, but low levels of customer social value. If Glossier can find ways to encourage customers to engage in activities that yield customer social value, it would be beneficial to the company. One way to do so is to identify a core group of existing customers who have the capacity and the desire to create customer social value through peer-to-peer selling and then to train them and compensate them to do so. Pros and cons of this decision are outlined below in **TN Table 2**.

TN Table 2 The Peer-to-Peer Sales Representative Program Decision

Pros	Cons
Amplifies existing organic influencer activity.	Loss of authenticity if P2P sellers receive compensation for influencing others.
Provides motivation for customers to increase social commerce activities.	Most customers will not be suited for or willing to do this type of work.
Provides status to customers who become P2P sellers.	Training and hand-holding will be necessary and will take staff time.
Authenticity is high because all peer sellers are existing customers.	Paying “friends” to help goes against consumer-brand relationship rules and may damage the relationship.
Acquires new customers and drives repeat sales.	

Source: Casewriter.

Or, Glossier can decide that its own customers may not have the skill sets nor the desire to truly influence the purchasing behaviors of their peers and may turn to professional influencers (paid influencers) to generate customer social value. As the matrix shows, professional influencers likely do not contribute much, if any, customer lifetime value, because most of them are not current users of Glossier. However, their large audiences and cultural capital provide them with the ability to influence lots of other consumers on behalf of Glossier. Pros and cons of this decision are outlined below in **TN Table 3**.

TN Table 3 The Paid Influencer Program Decision

Pros	Cons
Amplifies existing organic influencer activity.	Expensive.
Glossier has had success with CloudPaint program.	Glossier relies more on everyday women to endorse its brand rather than celebrities.
Huge reach opportunities to new audiences.	Inauthentic if paid influencers don't use the brand.
Beauty influencers are influential and aspirational and consumers look to them for new product ideas.	Takes influence power away from brand community.
Acquires new customers and drives repeat sales.	Mimics marketing tactics of Big Beauty brands

Source: Casewriter.

Both of these options raise the question of authenticity and how critical it is in the persuasion process. Social commerce works when consumers feel that their peers who are exerting influence over them have their best interests at heart. Once a commercial motive is introduced into the equation through paid peer-to-peer salespeople or paid influencers, persuasive abilities plummet, making customers more wary of others' influence on them.^c Glossier's relationships with its customers and its brand community is rooted in transparency and trust; students can debate whether this can be maintained as the community scales and as portions of its previously organic influence is commercialized to spur growth.

Pasture 5 Distribution Strategy and Scaling

In the last pasture of the discussion, instructors should guide students through some of the scaling decisions related to distribution strategy. The central question of the pasture is whether Glossier can remain fully direct-to-consumer e-commerce or needs to move into physical retail. Nuances related to this decision can be introduced by the instructor by introducing the choices of 1.) allowing wholesale distribution of Glossier products by retailers such as Sephora with a 40-50% retailer margin, 2.) opening more permanent showrooms to supplement the existing New York and Los Angeles showrooms, or 3.) investing in running experiential, limited-time-only pop-up retail locations across the country. Pros and cons of these decision are outlined in **TN Table 4**:

^c For more information about persuasion and influence via influencer marketing activities, see Avery, Jill and Ayelet Israeli (2020) "Influencer Marketing," *Harvard Business School Technical Note*, No. 9-520-075.

TN Table 4 DTC E-Commerce vs. Physical Retail

Remain DTC E-Commerce Only	Engage in Physical Retail
Maintains direct, identifiable connection with each customer.	Allows engagement of omnichannel shoppers; 80% of beauty products still sold through physical retail.
Ownership of full demand value chain.	Wholesaling allows costs associated with acquiring customers to be borne by retailer partner; they are likely more efficient at acquiring customers than Glossier given their scale advantages.
Ceiling to growth? 20% of shoppers buy via e-commerce, leaving most of market untapped.	Pop-ups take advantage of real estate deals and avoid high capital costs of own permanent retail.
Avoid paying wholesale margins of 40-50%.	Showrooms are producing significant sales per square foot.
Growing competition for online customers among beauty brands; driving CAC up for digital marketing.	Glossier customers who buy first in a physical retail store providing to buy more than those buying first on digital.
	Physical retail helps create branded experiences.
	Wholesaling provides instant market coverage and enhanced reach, generating brand awareness.
	Wholesale risks direct customer relationships.
	Wholesale reduces ability to execute full demand value chain social commerce.
	Showrooms are capital intensive.
	Pop-Ups can be expensive and take human resources to plan and execute.

Source: Casewriter.

For each of the distribution strategy options, students should be probed to explore what the impact of that decision might be on Glossier's relationships with its customers and with its brand community. Maintaining a DTC e-commerce model allows the greatest control over consumer-brand relationships and allows the company to easily curate and manage its brand community. Moving into wholesale requires turning over the front-line management of customer relationships to Sephora or other retailer partners. Glossier must ensure, through all of its other marketing decision making, that it secures and strengthens its customer relationships and brand community, as they are critical sources of competitive advantage.

What Happened?

Glossier sales grew by 300% in 2018 to an estimated \$100 million as the company expanded to 200 employees and 36 products. Three million consumers, including former U.S. First Lady Michelle Obama, Beyoncé, Reese Witherspoon, and Chrissy Teigen, joined the Glossier brand community.⁷ The company expanded its sales operations to seven countries, including UK, Denmark, Sweden, France, Ireland, Puerto Rico, and Canada. Pop-up stores were launched in Seattle, Miami, Boston, Austin, and London. The London pop-up reportedly attracted over 100,000 visitors in two months.⁸

Much of the \$52 million from the Series C round was spent on technology investments to improve the social commerce features of a Glossier shopping experience. Said Emily, “We have physical experiences, we have offline experiences, we have our product experience, we have our community experience. Offline has been really incredible in terms of community building, so we’ll be investing in offline, but in a much smaller way that we are investing in our digital experience and building that out in the next 12 months.”⁹ She continued,

E-commerce has made buying easier and more efficient, but discovery less fun and meaningful. Our direct-to-consumer model has enabled us to build uniquely powerful relationships with every single one of our customers on a personal level. We know that our customers are driven by the excitement of finding a new beauty product that they love, through someone they trust. This breadth of human connection and celebration of personal choice is core to who we are, and something we want to further facilitate and develop through new digital products.¹⁰

Explained Davis, “Much as social media has been fantastic and a huge boon for the color cosmetics side of beauty, it will continue to be a huge opportunity for us in a different format. That is why we are a technology company. We need to create those formats and build those forums for the conversations.”¹¹ He continued, “Understand what the right format is, build it, and allow people to connect, because that’s the key. Allow conversations to happen and allow people to connect with other people. Not only do you bind those people closely to the brand and the product, but you also have the ability to learn from these interactions.”¹² In press articles, he explained the company’s current strategic thinking about some of the decisions outlined in the case, stating,

We believe there is a lot of upside in retail, but we are in no hurry to go after it. Everything we do including physical retail will always be to drive a conversation online. We have a lot of low hanging fruit online and we are really focused on building our digital focus to engage in deeper, richer ways to better capture the data so we can play back the feedback to people and create more products to meet more needs that are underserved.¹³

We’re going to have showrooms, but we’re not going to do 25, because the point is not [stores]. We’d rather be patient and build the thing that’s going to be the future...Retail for us is about community, not money.¹⁴

If we can engage customers further up the sales funnel and earlier in product development and brand strategy, we will be in a position to create what people actually want... We innovate and develop products to meet those needs directly because we understand what they are.¹⁵

We are always focused on how we can use our customers to bring their other communities into our communities. We are making our customers into stakeholders. If

we make them stakeholders they help us create better products, but they also become our sales channel.¹⁶

Customer is at the heart of product development, customer is at the heart of strategy, and customer is at the heart of the sale. When your friend says, 'you have to try this thing', you listen. You cannot buy that much goodwill with all the advertising and the best creatives in the world. That's what we're focused on.¹⁷

The company experimented with a paid peer-to-peer sales program for its customers. It sent 500 Super Fans free product to encourage organic word-of-mouth. It limited paid influencer marketing and paid media efforts. It encouraged the submission of user feedback and tips that previously would have been featured on *Into the Gloss* and moved them to Glossier.com. A new sub-brand, dubbed Glossier Play, introduced glitter gels and color cosmetics to the product line, but was shuttered within a year after sales disappointed and existing products were folded into the existing Glossier product line.¹⁸

In March 2019, Glossier closed a Series D venture round led by Sequoia Capital, raising an additional \$100 million, which valued the company at \$1.2 billion.¹⁹ By 2019, the company was rumored to be considering going public via an IPO. During the holiday season of 2019, Glossier tested wholesaling by teaming up with Nordstrom's, a premium department store in the U.S., to create a pop-up 300 square foot store-within-a-store experience for its fragrance, Glossier You, in seven stores.²⁰

Said Davis,

Our long-term vision, five years out or whatever it is, is to be a massive, stand-alone company that has reinvented the way people engage with beauty brands, beauty products, and the customer experience. The customer today, facilitated by technology, is eager for and able to get a new and differentiated experience, and we think that if we can help deliver that, we can continue to build things that customers want. We don't know how big this company will be, but we believe the opportunity looks massive.²¹

He continued, "We are building a massive, stand-alone business with customer experience at the core. Glossier will be as big as any of the beauty businesses that are around today."²² Qualified Emily, "Regardless of how big we get, we're always going to create things that customers want and...maintain this direct relationship with them. By doing that, we'll be guided by their feedback. If we can make what they want, great, and if we can't, then we'll figure out the best way to get them what they want."²³ She remained committed to pushing toward a new type of social commerce, stating, "I think it becomes a hybrid. It's not really a social networking site, it's not really an e-commerce site, it is a beauty site that you go to to have beauty conversations, buy beauty products, learn about routines – it's combining those concepts together in a way that feels very organic to our community, versus sort of forced."²⁴

Suggested Additional Readings

Fournier, Susan and Lee (2009) "Getting Brand Communities Right," *Harvard Business Review*, April 2009.

Ofek, Elie; Barak Libai and Eitan Muller (2018) "Customer Lifetime Social Value (CLSV)," *Harvard Business School Technical Note*, No. 9-518-077.

Avery, Jill and Ayelet Israeli (2020) "Influencer Marketing," *Harvard Business School Technical Note*, No. 9-520-075.

Avery, Jill; Susan Fournier, and John Wittenbraker (2014) "Unlock the Mysteries of Your Customer Relationships" *Harvard Business Review*, July/August 2014.

Fournier, Susan (1998) "Consumer and Their Brands: Developing Relationship Theory in Consumer Research," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 24(4): 343-73.

Muniz, Albert M. Jr. and Thomas C. O'Guinn (2001) "Brand Community," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 27: 4: 412-432,

Endnotes

¹ Bezamat, Bia (2018) "Cannes Lions 2018: Glossier on how digital allows for individual connections at scale," *The Current Daily*, June 22, 2018, <https://thecurrentdaily.com/2018/06/22/glossier-digital-connections-scale/>, accessed 04/03/2020.

² Fournier, Susan (1998) "Consumers and Their Brands: Developing Relationship Theory in Consumer Research," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 24(4): 343-73.

³ Clark, M. S., & Mills, J. (1979) "Interpersonal attraction in exchange and communal relationships," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 37(1), 12-24.

⁴ Fournier, Susan (1998) "Consumers and Their Brands: Developing Relationship Theory in Consumer Research," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 24(4): 343-73.

⁵ Fournier, Susan (1998) "Consumers and Their Brands: Developing Relationship Theory in Consumer Research," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 24(4): 362.

⁶ Muniz, Albert M. Jr. and Thomas C. O'Guinn (2001) "Brand Community," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 27: 4: 412-432,

⁷ Turk, Victoria (2020) "How Glossier turned itself into a billion-dollar beauty," *Wired*, February 6, 2020, <https://www.wired.co.uk/article/how-to-build-a-brand-glossier>, accessed 04/03/2020.

⁸ Tse, Samantha (2020) "Glossier's London Pop-Up Will Stay for the Rest of the Year," *Forbes*, January 31, 2020, <https://www.forbes.com/sites/samanthatse/2020/01/31/glossiers-london-pop-up-will-stay-for-the-rest-of-the-year/#54c9f2793766>, accessed 04/03/2020.

⁹ Hays, Kali and Allison Collins (2018) "Glossier on the IPO Path," *WWD*, March 1, 2018, <https://wwd.com/beauty-industry-news/beauty-features/glossier-beauty-company-ipo-1202589159/>, accessed 01/21/2019.

¹⁰ Evans, Katie (2018) "Glossier's President Talks about Growth, Missteps, and Community," *Internet Retailer*, March 6, 2018, <https://www.digitalcommerce360.com/2018/03/06/glossier-president-talks-about-its-growth-missteps-and-community/>, accessed 01/21/2019.

¹¹ Danziger, Pamela N. (2018) "5 Reasons the Glossier is so Successful," *Forbes*, November 7, 2018, <https://www.forbes.com/sites/pamdanziger/2018/11/07/5-keys-to-beauty-brand-glossiers-success/#363bab4b417d>, accessed 01/21/2019.

¹² Female Founders Fund (2018) "Glossier President and CFO Henry Davis on Building a Passionate Community," *Female Founders Fund*, October 30, 2018, <https://blog.femalefoundersfund.com/glossier-president-cfo-henry-davis-on-building-a-passionate-community-1e407eaeed13>, accessed 01/21/2019.

¹³ Danziger, Pamela N. (2018) "5 Reasons the Glossier is so Successful," *Forbes*, November 7, 2018, <https://www.forbes.com/sites/pamdanziger/2018/11/07/5-keys-to-beauty-brand-glossiers-success/#363bab4b417d>, accessed 01/21/2019.

¹⁴ Female Founders Fund (2018) "Glossier President and CFO Henry Davis on Building a Passionate Community," *Female Founders Fund*, October 30, 2018, <https://blog.femalefoundersfund.com/glossier-president-cfo-henry-davis-on-building-a-passionate-community-1e407eaeed13>, accessed 01/21/2019.

¹⁵ Danziger, Pamela N. (2018) "5 Reasons the Glossier is so Successful," *Forbes*, November 7, 2018, <https://www.forbes.com/sites/pamdanziger/2018/11/07/5-keys-to-beauty-brand-glossiers-success/#363bab4b417d>, accessed 01/21/2019.

¹⁶ Danziger, Pamela N. (2018) "5 Reasons the Glossier is so Successful," *Forbes*, November 7, 2018, <https://www.forbes.com/sites/pamdanziger/2018/11/07/5-keys-to-beauty-brand-glossiers-success/#363bab4b417d>, accessed 01/21/2019.

¹⁷ Rogers, Charlotte (2018) "Why direct-to-consumer beauty brand Glossier is ripping up the marketing playbook," *Marketing Week*, June 25, 2018, <https://www.marketingweek.com/glossier-ripping-up-marketing-playbook/>, accessed 01/21/2019.

¹⁸ Sharkey, Lauren (2020) "What Happened to Glossier Play?" *Bustle*, February 21, 2020, <https://www.bustle.com/p/what-happened-to-glossier-play-21820428>, accessed 04/03/2020.

- ¹⁹ Turk, Victoria (2020) "How Glossier turned itself into a billion-dollar beauty," *Wired*, February 6, 2020, <https://www.wired.co.uk/article/how-to-build-a-brand-glossier>, accessed 04/03/2020.
- ²⁰ Strugatz, Rachel (2019) "Inside Glossier's First Major Retail Partnership," *Business of Fashion*, December 3, 2019, <https://www.businessoffashion.com/articles/beauty/inside-glossiers-first-major-retail-partnership>, accessed 04/03/2020.
- ²¹ Hays, Kali and Allison Collins (2018) "Glossier on the IPO Path," March 1, 2018, <https://wwd.com/beauty-industry-news/beauty-features/glossier-beauty-company-ipo-1202589159/>, accessed 01/21/2019.
- ²² Hays, Kali and Allison Collins (2018) "Glossier on the IPO Path," March 1, 2018, <https://wwd.com/beauty-industry-news/beauty-features/glossier-beauty-company-ipo-1202589159/>, accessed 01/21/2019.
- ²³ Hays, Kali and Allison Collins (2018) "Glossier on the IPO Path," March 1, 2018, <https://wwd.com/beauty-industry-news/beauty-features/glossier-beauty-company-ipo-1202589159/>, accessed 01/21/2019.
- ²⁴ Turk, Victoria (2020) "How Glossier turned itself into a billion-dollar beauty," *Wired*, February 6, 2020, <https://www.wired.co.uk/article/how-to-build-a-brand-glossier>, accessed 04/03/2020.